The Research Process

Things to Remember

- Great research takes time and effort.
- Topics can cross multiple subjects, from Art to Zoology.
- Learn about and think critically about your topic.
- Narrow your topic to the specific questions you want answered, if it is for an assignment, use the assignment prompts to help you; refine and hone down your thesis.
- Keep a record of each article, website, textbook, blog, etc.
    - You will need this for your APA reference page and in-text citations.

Collect Information

- Review what you already know.
- If the subject is new to you:
    - Learn the basics using encyclopedias, textbooks, and credible sources such as:
        - .edu websites
        - .gov websites
        - LIRN Databases – (recommended: Gale in Context, or the Gale Topic Finder)
- Hone down your topic and refine your inquiry. Be prepared to make adjustments based on available resources.

What Exactly Are You Researching?

- Identify your topic (e.g., Global Warming, GMOs, Aviation Industry, CREW methods).
- Ask yourself:
    - What aspects of this topic interest you?
    - Are there different ways to view or interpret this topic?
- Use a thesaurus to broaden terminology and redefine search terms.
- Consider the **who, what, why, when, where, and how** of your topic.
    - Example question: *What happens in a nuclear fallout?*
    - Refined question: *What happened to wildlife after Chernobyl and Fukushima?*
- Identify key words and ideas related to your topic, such as:
    - Radiation, nuclear fallout, radiation poisoning, atom bomb, blast zone
    - Potassium iodine, casualties, long-term damage, thermal radiation
    - Gamma radiation, contamination, pollution, heavy water
- Determine which subject areas intersect with your research:
    - Nuclear Physics
    - Sociology
    - Health & Medical
    - Ecology
    - Biology
    - Astrophysics

Focus Your Research

- Collect up-to-date information.
- Use relevant periodicals and primary sources from:
    - Trade publications
    - Scholarly sources
- Avoid sites like Wikipedia.
    - Stick to .edu and .gov websites.

    - If using commercial or organizational sites, clearly justify their relevance.
- Gather in-depth information by reviewing:
    - New research and emerging ideas
    - Books, research studies, surveys, and experiments
    - Textbooks are not only foundational, they offer additional references in the back of the book. Use those to gather more information and resources.
- Keep careful records of your sources:
    - Create a Word document to save links and citations.
    - Title it with something related to your topic.
    - Copy and paste citations directly from databases to save time later.

Evaluate Your Resources

- Who is/are the author or authors, group, or editor?
- What are their credentials?
- Do they show any bias?
- Who is the intended audience?
- Is the resource opinion-based or objectively written?
- Does it compare and contrast different viewpoints?
- What is the purpose of the work?
    - To educate, inform, persuade, or influence?
- How does the source help answer your research questions or assignment prompts?
- Is the information relevant to your inquiry?
- Does the resource help support or answer your thesis?